

The new UI

The touch-based UIs of all phones and tablets centre around icons (Microsoft may call them tiles, but they're still big things that you tap on with a finger), and BlackBerry 10 is no different in that respect. As of now, no one has come up with a more intuitive interface than touch for phones, and we're still waiting for someone to design something other than icons/tiles for us to tap on like bored monkeys. Perhaps they never will, who knows.

What BlackBerry has done is to keep the interface familiar (for touch users of other OSes), and also thrown in some new methods and actions to keep things lively. Most important of these changes are the gestures that we'll explain in a bit. Also, the BlackBerry Hub concept of gathering all your data in one place, and an easily accessible Active Frame screen that shows all currently running apps, makes it easier to multi-task.

Gestures

As soon as you start up any one of the phones, you're given a tutorial on how to use the phone, including the gestures you can perform. This is important for those who have not used the PlayBook before, and although this requires a small amount of learning, it's so intuitive that you'll be used to it in under a day. Another testament to how intuitive these gestures are is the fact that after using a BlackBerry 10 device for a week or so, we've found ourselves trying similar gestures on iOS, Windows or Android phones, and failing miserably of course. What's important to remember about the gestures is that swiping up and down has to be done from the bezel (the glass frame around the screen). Thus, you swipe into the screen from outside it to perform the gestures – swiping up or down within the screen boundary just vertical scrolls. You can also swipe and hold, and “peek” into the next screen. This allows you to perform a quick check of important notifications even when you have an app running in full screen. Great for multi-tasking; and this peek-feature is the foundation that the usability of the BlackBerry 10 OS design is based on.

Let's take a look at some of the system-wide gestures you will have to be familiar with when using a BlackBerry 10 device.

Swiping up

To do this action, place your finger below the bottom edge of the screen and swipe up towards the middle of the screen. This, for all practical purposes,